DURGAVATI, RANI OF THE GONDS

The land of Gondwana in central India was inhabited in the sixteenth century by Dravidian-speaking tribes who, according to Abu'l Fazl, 'live in the countryside, where they occupy themselves with eating, drinking and copulating'. He further points out that 'they are a base tribe and the people of India despise them…' The truth, however, was more complicated, for Gondwana was ruled by Rani Durgavati, who even Abu'l Fazl had to admit was an exemplary leader. 'In courage, tactics and generosity she had attained a high level and through these good qualities she had unified the whole country.' She led her troops into battle herself, 20,000 expert cavalrymen and 1,000 fierce elephants. She was a good shot with the bow and arrow as well as the musket and it was her habit, whenever she heard that a lion had appeared in her kingdom, to drink no water until she had shot it.

Rani Durgavati was born into the prestigious but impoverished dynasty of the Chandels, and her father was compelled to marry her to Dalpat Shah, of the less illustrious but considerably wealthier Gond dynasty of Garha Katanga, which at that time included some Rajput and Gond principalities. When Dalpat Shah died in 1548, Rani Durgavati's son, Vir Narayan, was only five years old but the rani took over as regent of the kingdom with aplomb and ruled her kingdom wisely and well for sixteen years, amassing riches and treasures. She defended her kingdom with admirable courage, repulsing the attacks of Baz Bahadaur and some ambitious Timurid mirzas. She also had, according to Nizamuddin Ahmad, 'a complete share of beauty and grace'. Her only fault, sighed Abu'l Fazl, was that 'she was overly proud of her success and was not obedient to the imperial threshold'.

When Akbar decided to bring these prosperous and fertile kingdoms, rich in forests and in war elephants, into the Mughal Empire, he sent Asaf Khan, a Persian courtier, to subdue the region after initial negotiations had failed. Asaf Khan first conquered Panna and then turned towards Gondwana. Rani Durgavati strapped on her armour and, using her knowledge of her country, the steep ravines, the thundering Narbada, the unknowable forests, lured the Mughal forces into a trap and inflicted a